Contemporary Cultures of the Indus Civilisation

Several groups including pastoral people, farmers and hunter-gatherers lived in the Indus region. The Indus region had villages and large towns. The population of that time was mixed. Innumerable communities of hunters-gatherers, pastoral people and farmers, from Kanyakumari to Kashmir and Gujarat to Arunachal Pradesh could have existed during this period. Their history is also equally important, as cultural and ecological knowledge of all these groups contributed to Indian culture.

While the Indus Civilisation was flourishing in the north-western part of India, several cultures were developing in different parts of India. In the southern part of the subcontinent, Kerala and Sri Lanka were given to hunting and gathering. The Harappans who had knowledge of water crafts might have had connections and interactions with South India, but no clear archaeological evidence on this is available. The northern part of South India, i.e. the Karnataka and Andhra region, had Neolithic cultures, engaged in pastoralism and plough agriculture. Similarly, the Chalcolithic cultures were prevalent in Deccan and western India, while Neolithic cultures permeated northern India including Kashmir, Ganges valley and central and eastern India. Thus India was a cultural mosaic during the time of the Harappans.

Decline

The Indus Valley Civilisation declined from about 1900 BCE. Changes in climate, decline of the trade with the Mesopotamia, and the drying of the river and water resources due to continuous drought are some of the reasons attributed by historians for the decline. Invasions, floods and shifting of the river course are also cited as reasons for the ruin of Indus civilisation. In course of time, the people shifted to the southern and eastern directions from the Indus region.

SUMMARY

- The history of India began in the pre-historic times about 2 million years ago.
- Numerous groups of people moved into this land from the pre-historic times. These groups adapted to their environment and created specific ways of life according to the ecological moorings.
- People who made hand axes lived in India from two million years ago. Various communities occupied the entire breadth and width of the country from the Mesolithic times and laid the cultural foundations of India.
- The combined contribution of all these groups contributed to India's pluralistic culture today.
- The diverse languages and cultures of India reveal the complex processes associated with Indian history.
- The first urbanisation emerged around the Indus Valley Civilisation about 2600 BCE. While Indus Valley Civilisation was a major cultural system in north-western India, several cultures existed across India contemporaneously.

EXERCISE

F13SL

I. Choose the Correct Answer

1. The period before the development of script is called _____.
   (a) Pre-historic (b) Historic
   (c) palaeolithic (d) Neolithic
2. The earliest age in history is called _____.
   (a) Old Stone Age (b) New Stone Age
   (c) Copper Age (d) Iron Age
3. The first Palaeolithic tools were identified in _____.
   (a) 1860 (b) 1863 (c) 1873 (d) 1883

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